Lines

By Tony Glazer

Lights up on a studio apartment. A few boxes litter the floor someone is either coming or going. A woman PATRICIA stands in the center of the apartment while JONATHAN stands in the door jamb with a box cradled in his arms. Silence. Then ...

INTRODUCTION

ACTOR: *Relationships can be difficult under normal circumstances.*
ACTRESS: *But when the bond is challenged by additional outside forces. . .Cancer . . . infidelity . . .*
ACTOR: *How in the world does a couple weather the storm?*
ACTRESS: *Once you've crossed the line, can you ever make it back?*
ACTOR: *And when all you want to do is blame someone, is forgiveness even a possibility?*
TOGETHER: *Lines by Tony Glazer*

JONATHAN: That's it. That's everything.

PATRICIA: Last box. *(Awkwardness. Then ...)* I've called the utility companies.

JONATHAN: Good, that's . . . I called cable and Sunday Times delivery.

PATRICIA: Everyone in the building just took turns stealing our copy anyway.

JONATHAN: Environmentalists.

PATRICIA: At least they recycle. *(JONATHAN notices something.)*

JONATHAN: Do you want to take the curtains?

PATRICIA: No.

JONATHAN: Really? You spent so much time picking / them-

PATRICIA: *(gently interrupting)* Let's, let's just leave them for the next tenant.

JONATHAN: Sure.

PATRICIA: I mean, it's nice to come to a place for the first . . . it's nice to come to the new place you're staying in and find curtains already hanging there.

JONATHAN: Yeah.

PATRICIA: That never happens. People almost always take theirs so when you come in

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and see them hanging up it's more than just one more thing off your list. It makes everything feel more like a . . .

JONATHAN: Home. *(Awkwardness. Finally . . .)* I should go.

PATRICIA: I won't be much longer.

JONATHAN: You're set with everything?

PATRICIA: I'm good.

JONATHAN: You don't need any help with / the rest of

PATRICIA: *(gently interrupting)* No, no. I'm fine. I've got it.

JONATHAN: Okay. Okay, then. *(Beat. Then . . .)*

PATRICIA: We did try.

JONATHAN: No one could accuse us of not making the effort.

PATRICIA: We ran the gamut.

JONATHAN: We did.

PATRICIA: Self-help books.

JONATHAN: That vacation.

PATRICIA: Couples' therapy.

JONATHAN: I still don't think that guy was licensed.

PATRICIA: You should let that go.

JONATHAN: Neither of our insurance companies would recognize him, Pat.

PATRICIA: That doesn't mean anything, John.

JONATHAN: Plus he kept wanting us to color in books. What licensed therapist asks you to do that?

PATRICIA: Everyone has their own method.

JONATHAN: Only the "unlicensed ones" involve crayons.

PATRICIA: Don't be so judgmental.

JONATHAN: Wasn't that why we were there?

PATRICIA: We were there to reflect-not judge.

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JONATHAN: How do you accomplish that without some form of critical thought?

PATRICIA: Critical thought about us not-it doesn't matter.

JONATHAN: No.

PATRICIA: He didn't help anyway.

JONATHAN: He made it worse. Or better. Depending . . . *(The two stand just there, until . . . .)* See you around.

PATRICIA: No.

JONATHAN: No, what?

PATRICIA: You won't "see me around." We broke up, John. We just divided up our belongings and are now going our separate ways. You don't "see each other around" after you do something like that.

JONATHAN: It's just an expression.

PATRICIA: Find a better one.

JONATHAN: Okay. Goodbye.

(JONATHAN exits. PATRICIA begins to cry quietly. JONATHAN returns as if to say something. He stands there, looking at her, affected, before walking to her, putting an arm around her. She s startled at first but then, realizing that it s him, relaxes back into her sadness.)

JONATHAN: It's okay.

PATRICIA: It's not.

JONATHAN: I know.

PATRICIA: Then don't say something is "okay" when you know it's not.

JONATHAN: All right. *(He continues to hold her. She continues to cry until it becomes awkward again and they separate.)*

PATRICIA: I'm fine now.

JONATHAN: Goodbye. *(JONATHAN moves towards to the door.)*

PATRICIA: I just . . . *(JONATHAN turns back.)* I don't . . .

JONATHAN: You slept with my brother.

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PATRICIA: I know, John. I was there when it happened.

JONATHAN: You couldn't have thought sleeping with him was going to come without any consequences.

PATRICIA: I didn't.

JONATHAN: And yet you did it all the same knowing full well it was going to lead us right to this moment.

PATRICIA: It wasn't that simple.

JONATHAN: He's my brother.

PATRICIA: You're repeating yourself.

JONATHAN: My stupid, back-stabbing, unemployed, selfish and irresponsible brother.

PATRICIA: At least he could look at my scars without flinching. *(Almost unconsciously, JONATHAN looks to PATRICIA s chest before looking away.)*

JONATHAN: No . . . don't you . . . don't turn that . . . that's not . . .

PATRICIA: Fair? No it isn't. It's not even decent.

JONATHAN: It's not . . . accurate.

PATRICIA: Accurate enough.

JONATHAN: You changed.

PATRICIA: I survived. *(Pause. Finally . . .)*

JONATHAN: I should really go.

PATRICIA: You can't color inside the lines.

JONATHAN: What's that?

PATRICIA: At the therapist's office. When he asked us to color. I saw you couldn't color inside the lines. When I saw that I knew it wasn't going to work out.

JONATHAN: Is that right?

PATRICIA: I could never be with someone who couldn't do something as basic as color inside the lines. You have a problem with lines.

JONATHAN: And you don't. Not with crossing them, anyway.

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PATRICIA: Screw you.

JONATHAN: See you around. *(JONATHAN is about to exit again.)*

PATRICIA: Coward. *(JONATHAN stops himself, this last statement striking a nerve. Finally . . .)*

JONATHAN: I was there for you. *(PATRICIA does not respond.)* By your side. Through everything. All of it . . . the tests, the insurance forms, the surgery, all that . . . poison. I was there. One hundred percent. Until you got well.

PATRICIA: Your point?

JONATHAN: I loved you.

PATRICIA: Isn't that easy to say?

JONATHAN: I still do for what's it's worth.

PATRICIA: Which isn't much.

JONATHAN: Right.

PATRICIA: Because you're a coward.

JONATHAN: We've been through this already. I don't need to hear-

PATRICIA: I'm very blessed, actually.

JONATHAN: Of course you are. You're alive.

PATRICIA: No. I'm blessed about you. *(JONATHAN just stares. Then ...)* Somewhere between sleeping with your brother and the coloring books and you never quite being able to look at my chest it finally occurred to me just how amazing it was to actually be able to see you. See who you really are. Startling, really-the clarity of that moment. I owe you. I never would have challenged our situation. We were on a set track, you and I. We were a straight shot to marriage and kids. I never would have got off that track-not on my own. Of course, now that you've stepped off, not only do I know that I never could be with someone this fundamentally bunched over the lines on my chest, I would never want to be. *(Beat. Then . . .)*

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JONATHAN: *(sincere)* It's not you, Patricia. It's not / that I don't . . .

PATRICIA: *(interrupting)* We don't have to revisit / this anymore.

JONATHAN: *(interrupting)* I can't explain it. I'm not proud of it. It just makes me uncomfortable.

PATRICIA: Stop saying "it." It is not "it." I had to listen to you in that pretend therapist's office go on about "it" for months. Well, before you walk out that door, let's make one thing perfectly clear. "It" is "me," John. You don't have a problem with "it"-it's me you can't look at, can't touch, can't love.

JONATHAN: No, you . . . I don't have a problem with you. You're twisting this . . . it's not . . . you.

PATRICIA: Prove it. *(Impulsively, and with her back to the audience, PATRICIA begins to open her blouse.)*

JONATHAN: What are you . . .

PATRICIA: If that's true you have to prove it. Right now. Before you go, before we never see each other again, make me believe our entire relationship wasn't a lie.

JONATHAN: Patricia . . . don't . . .

PATRICIA: No, Jonathan. If you loved me-still love me, like you say-then you have to see "me." Not "it." Me.

JONATHAN: Please, Pat. I . . .

(PATRICIA has exposed her chest. JONATHAN, after a moment, looks and then, very tentatively, approaches. After a moment, he puts a hand on PATRICIA' s chest. His hand stays there for a long time until ..).

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Tony Glazer
Book: The Best Ten-Minute Plays 2012
ISBN: 978-1575257938
Publisher: Smith and Kraus
Date (Month/Year): June 2013

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